death with Nazi Germany was likely and built the world's biggest war machine to prepare for it. But he hamstrung this machine both diplomatically and psychologically.

On the diplomatic level, in 1939–41, Stalin gambled that he could goad the 'capitalists' to fight and exhaust one another while the USSR nurtured and even increased its power. He therefore made a pact with Hitler in 1939 and allowed the Germans to conquer much of Poland and western Europe, while the USSR attacked or alienated almost all its neighbours. In 1939–40 the Soviets invaded and occupied eastern Poland; annexed Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania; and conquered parts of Finland and Romania. Finland and Romania, which could have acted as neutral buffers on the USSR's flanks, consequently became implacable enemies. Even in the spring of 1941, Stalin still refused to make a pre-emptive alliance with Britain and made no move to hinder the Nazi conquest of Yugoslavia and Greece, thereby losing his last potential allies on the European continent. When Hitler struck on 22 June 1941, the USSR was isolated.

In theory, the war machine Stalin built could have handled the Nazi onslaught even in isolation. The territories conquered since 1939 provided depth to Soviet defences, and the Soviet military advantage seemed overwhelming. On the first day of the invasion the Soviets had 15,000 tanks, 15,000 warplanes and 37,000 artillery pieces on the European front, facing 3,300 German tanks, 2,250 warplanes and 7,146 guns.[116] But in one of history's greatest military catastrophes, within a month the Soviets lost 11,700 tanks (78 per cent), 10,000 warplanes (67 per cent), and 19,000 artillery pieces (51 per cent).[117] Stalin also lost all the territories he had conquered in 1939–40 and much of the Soviet heartland. By 16 July the Germans were in Smolensk, 370 kilometers from Moscow.

The causes of the debacle have been debated ever since 1941, but most scholars agree that a significant factor was the psychological costs of Stalinism. For years the regime terrorised its people, punished initiative and individuality and encouraged submissiveness and conformity. This undermined the soldiers' motivation. Especially in the first months of the war, before the horrors of Nazi rule were fully realised, Red Army soldiers surrendered in huge numbers; between three and four million were taken captive by the end of 1941.[118] Even when they fought tenaciously, Red Army units suffered from a lack of initiative. Officers who had survived the purges were fearful of taking independent actions, while younger officers